THE WHOLE STORY · SMALL GROUP GUIDE · LESSON 9 OF 26

Sinai: The Law and the Covenant

Exodus 19–24; 32

> **The big idea:** God rescued Israel first, then gave them his law. The law is a Father teaching his freed children how to live. It shows us our sin, and it points us to Jesus, who kept it for us.

Before you meet: Read

Exodus 19:1–6, 16–19 | Exodus 20:1–21 | Exodus 24:3–11 | Exodus 32:1–20 | Hebrews 12:18–24

Open (5 minutes)

When you hear the word law, what comes to mind first? Did you grow up with rules that felt loving, or rules that felt harsh?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I bore you on _____ wings and brought you to _____." *(Exodus 19:4)*

"You shall be my treasured _____ among all peoples, for all the earth is mine; and you shall be to me a kingdom of _____ and a holy nation." *(Exodus 19:5–6)*

"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of _____." *(Exodus 20:2)*

"Behold the _____ of the covenant that the LORD has made with you in accordance with all these words." *(Exodus 24:8)*

Around the golden calf the people said, "These are your _____, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!" *(Exodus 32:4)*

"The LORD, the LORD, a God _____ and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast _____ and faithfulness." *(Exodus 34:6)*

Discuss

1. God rescued Israel before he gave them the law. Why does that order matter? What would change if it were the other way around? *Exodus 19:4; 20:2*

2. God called Israel "a kingdom of priests." Peter calls the church "a royal priesthood." What could that look like for you this week? *Exodus 19:6; 1 Peter 2:9*

3. Why were the people afraid at Sinai? Is that kind of fear of God healthy or harmful? Why? *Exodus 19:16–18; 20:18–21*

4. The law works as a mirror, a restraint, and a guide. Which one have you experienced most? Explain. *Romans 3:20; Galatians 3:24*

5. Israel promised, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do," and weeks later made a golden calf. Why do you think they turned so fast? What do you turn to when God seems slow? *Exodus 24:7; 32:1–4*

6. Moses asked to be blotted out for Israel and could not be. Jesus was cut off for his people and became a curse for them. What does that tell you about him? *Exodus 32:32–33; Galatians 3:13*

Apply this week

Before you read the Ten Commandments this week, read Exodus 20:2 out loud and remember what God has already done for you. Then take one commandment a day. Ask honestly where you have broken it in thought, word, or deed, confess it to God, and thank Jesus, who kept it for you.

Memory verse

"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."

Exodus 20:2

Pray

Thank God that he rescued you before he asked anything of you. Confess where his law shows you have fallen short. Ask him to write his law on your heart, and thank Jesus, who kept the law you broke and bore the curse you deserved.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 9

Sinai: The Law and the Covenant

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Exodus 19:1–6 and 20:1–21 aloud together. Then read 32:1–6.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the moral, ceremonial, and judicial laws diagram in the full lesson, and the three uses of the law.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 10 (Exodus 25–27 and 40).

Main points to land

1. Rescue comes before law. The Ten Commandments open with what God has already done (Exodus 20:2). We obey because we have been rescued, not in order to be rescued (WSC 44).
2. God is holy. At Sinai sinful people could not come near him, and they needed a mediator to stand between them and God (20:19, 21; Deuteronomy 5:5).
3. The moral law, summed up in the Ten Commandments, binds everyone. The ceremonial laws pointed to Christ and are fulfilled. Israel's civil laws ended with the nation, though their justice still teaches us (WCF 19.3–5). The Sabbath now falls on the Lord's Day (WCF 21.7).
4. The law is a mirror that shows our sin and drives us to Christ, a restraint on evil, and a guide for believers. It can no longer condemn those who are in Christ (WCF 19.6).
5. Sinai was a covenant of grace, with a mediator, blood sacrifice, and a merciful God (34:6; WCF 7.5). Israel broke it. Jesus kept the law for us, bore its curse, and brings a better covenant that writes the law on our hearts (Jeremiah 31:33; Hebrews 12:24).

Answer key (Observe)

1. eagles'; myself
2. possession; priests
3. slavery
4. blood
5. gods
6. merciful; love

Questions people will ask

Do Christians have to keep all of Moses' laws, like avoiding pork or stoning lawbreakers?
No. The ceremonial laws (sacrifices, food laws, festivals) pictured Christ and are fulfilled in him. Israel's civil laws, including their penalties, ended with Israel as a nation, though the justice beneath them still teaches us (WCF 19.3–4). Some of those laws sound harsh to us, and it is fine to say so. Keep the group on the moral law, which still binds us all.

Was Israel saved by keeping the law, while we are saved by grace?
No. God rescued Israel before he gave the law, and he gave sacrifices for the times they failed. Believers in Israel were saved by grace through faith in the promised Messiah, just as we are (WCF 7.5). The new covenant brings the same salvation in fuller light.

Should Christians worship on Saturday, since the commandment names the seventh day?
One day in seven belongs to God, a pattern older than Israel (Genesis 2:3). Since Jesus rose on the first day of the week, his people have gathered on that day, "the Lord's day" (Revelation 1:10). The Westminster Confession calls it the Christian Sabbath (WCF 21.7).

Why did God judge the people so severely after the golden calf?
Weeks after promising to obey, the nation worshiped an idol and credited it with their rescue. That was treason against the God who had just saved them. The judgment was real (32:28, 35), and it is right to feel its weight. But most of the people lived, God forgave, and he renewed the covenant. The story shows how much we need a better Mediator than Moses.

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that you rescued us before you asked anything of us, and that your law is a Father's instruction to children you have already brought home. Where your law shows us our sin, lead us to Jesus, who kept it for us and bore its curse in our place. Write your law on our hearts, and teach us to love you and our neighbors. Amen.